

Treatment Guide

What each treatment at Bright Smile Dental involves, step by step

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Sample content: Bright Smile Dental is a fictional practice. This document was written for a software demonstration and is not medical advice.

How to use this Treatment Guide

This Treatment Guide describes the six treatments offered at Bright Smile Dental: check-up and clean, dental fillings, root canal treatment, tooth extraction, dental implants and teeth whitening. For each treatment it explains what the treatment is, who it is for, what happens during the appointment, how long it takes, and the possible side effects and alternatives.

This guide gives general information only. Your dentist will explain what is right for you, and nothing in this guide replaces the advice you are given at your appointment. Instructions for looking after your mouth after each treatment are in the separate Aftercare Instructions document. Current prices are shown on the Services page of the website.

Treatments at a glance

Treatment	Appointment length	Usual number of visits	Local anaesthetic
Check-up and clean	30 minutes	1	Not usually needed
Dental filling	30 minutes	1	Usually
Root canal treatment	90 minutes	1 or 2	Yes
Tooth extraction	30 minutes	1	Yes
Dental implant	90 minutes per surgical visit	Several, over months	Yes
Teeth whitening	60 minutes	1	No

Check-up and clean: what it is

A check-up and clean is a routine examination of your teeth, gums and mouth combined with a professional clean. The check-up finds problems such as tooth decay and gum disease early, when they are easier to treat. The clean, also called a scale and polish, removes the hard tartar that brushing at home cannot shift.

Bright Smile Dental recommends a check-up and clean every six months for most patients. Patients who are being treated for gum disease may be asked to come more often.

Check-up and clean: what happens

During a check-up and clean appointment at Bright Smile Dental:

1. The dentist asks about any problems and checks your medical history for changes.
2. The dentist examines each tooth, your gums, and the soft tissues of your mouth, tongue and throat, which includes a check for signs of mouth cancer.
3. X-rays are taken if they are needed. Most adults need X-rays every one to two years, not at every visit.
4. Tartar and plaque are removed using a fine ultrasonic scaler and hand instruments.
5. The teeth are polished to remove surface stains.
6. The dentist explains what they found and gives advice on brushing, flossing and diet.

A check-up and clean is not usually painful. Some patients feel mild sensitivity during the clean, and gums may bleed a little if they are inflamed. If you find the clean uncomfortable, tell the dentist, who can slow down or use a numbing gel.

Dental fillings: what they are

A dental filling repairs a tooth that has been damaged by decay or a small crack. The damaged part of the tooth is removed and the space is filled to restore the tooth's shape and strength and to stop decay spreading.

Bright Smile Dental uses tooth-coloured composite fillings, which are matched to the shade of the surrounding tooth. Composite fillings bond to the tooth, so less healthy tooth needs to be removed than with older silver amalgam fillings.

Dental fillings: what happens

A dental filling appointment at Bright Smile Dental lasts 30 minutes:

1. The area is numbed with a local anaesthetic injection, so you should not feel pain during the filling. Numbing gel is applied first to make the injection more comfortable.
2. The decayed or damaged part of the tooth is removed with a small drill.
3. The tooth is cleaned and a bonding agent is applied.
4. The composite filling material is placed in layers and each layer is hardened with a blue curing light.
5. The filling is shaped and polished, and your bite is checked so the filling does not feel high.

Your lip, cheek and tongue may stay numb for two to four hours after a filling. Mild sensitivity to cold for a few weeks after a filling is common and normally settles on its own.

Dental fillings: alternatives and when a filling is not enough

If a cavity is very large, a filling may not be strong enough to hold the tooth together. In that case the dentist may recommend a crown, which covers the whole tooth. If decay has reached the nerve in the centre of the tooth, root canal treatment may be needed before the tooth can be restored. Leaving decay untreated allows it to grow, and it can lead to pain, infection and eventually losing the tooth.

Root canal treatment: what it is

Root canal treatment saves a tooth whose nerve, called the pulp, has become infected or badly inflamed. The pulp sits in narrow channels, called root canals, that run down inside each root of the tooth. When the pulp is infected, root canal treatment removes it, cleans and disinfects the canals, and seals them so infection cannot return.

Root canal treatment is usually needed because of deep decay, a crack in the tooth, a large old filling, or an injury. Signs that a tooth may need root canal treatment include lasting pain, pain when biting, sensitivity to hot or cold that lingers after the hot or cold has gone, a darkening tooth, or swelling of the gum near the tooth. Some infected teeth cause no symptoms at all and are found on an X-ray.

At Bright Smile Dental, complex root canal cases are carried out by Dr Omar Haddad, who has a master's degree in endodontics, the specialist field of root canal treatment.

Root canal treatment: what happens

A root canal treatment appointment at Bright Smile Dental lasts 90 minutes:

1. The tooth is numbed with local anaesthetic. Root canal treatment should feel similar to having a filling.
2. A thin rubber sheet, called a dental dam, is placed around the tooth to keep it clean and dry and to stop anything being swallowed.
3. A small opening is made in the top of the tooth to reach the pulp.

4. The infected pulp is removed and the canals are cleaned, shaped and disinfected using fine instruments and antibacterial solutions.
5. The canals are filled and sealed with a rubber-like material.
6. The opening in the tooth is closed with a filling.

Many root canal treatments are completed in one visit. If a tooth is badly infected or has unusually shaped canals, the treatment is done over two visits, with medicine placed inside the tooth and a temporary filling in between.

Root canal treatment: after the treatment

A tooth often feels tender for a few days after root canal treatment, especially when biting. This tenderness normally improves steadily.

A tooth that has had root canal treatment can become more brittle over time, particularly a back tooth. The dentist will often recommend a crown to protect the tooth from breaking. Most root canal treatments are successful and the tooth can last for many years. The main alternative to root canal treatment is extracting the tooth.

Tooth extraction: what it is

A tooth extraction is the removal of a tooth that cannot be saved, for example because it is too badly decayed or broken, is loose because of gum disease, or is a wisdom tooth causing repeated problems. Bright Smile Dental will always discuss the alternatives with you before recommending an extraction.

Most extractions are simple extractions, where the tooth is loosened and lifted out. A surgical extraction is needed when a tooth has broken off at the gum line or has not come through fully, such as an impacted wisdom tooth. At Bright Smile Dental, surgical extractions are carried out by Dr Mei Tanaka, who has a master's degree in oral surgery.

Tooth extraction: what happens

A tooth extraction appointment at Bright Smile Dental lasts 30 minutes:

1. The dentist checks your medical history, including any blood-thinning medicines.
2. The area around the tooth is numbed with local anaesthetic. You will feel pressure during the extraction but you should not feel sharp pain.
3. The tooth is gently loosened and removed.
4. You bite on a gauze pad to help a blood clot form in the empty socket.
5. Stitches are sometimes placed, usually ones that dissolve on their own.
6. The dentist explains how to look after the socket and gives you written aftercare instructions before you leave.

Before you leave, the dentist will also talk through options for replacing the tooth if it is needed, such as a dental implant, a bridge or a denture.

Tooth extraction: risks

Most extractions heal without problems. Possible problems after a tooth extraction include bleeding, swelling, bruising and, in a small number of cases, dry socket. Dry socket happens when the blood clot in the socket is lost or does not form properly. It causes worsening pain two to four days after the extraction and is more common in smokers. The Aftercare Instructions document explains how to lower the risk of dry socket and what to do if you think you have it.

Dental implants: what they are

A dental implant replaces a missing tooth. A small titanium post is placed into the jawbone where the tooth root used to be. Over the following months the bone grows onto the implant and holds it firmly, a process called osseointegration. A crown that looks like a natural tooth is then fixed on top of the implant.

Dental implants can replace a single tooth, several teeth, or support a bridge or denture. Unlike a bridge, an implant does not need the neighbouring teeth to be cut down. At Bright Smile Dental, all implants are placed by Dr Mei Tanaka.

Dental implants: who is suitable

Most adults with good general health and healthy gums can have dental implants. Before starting, the dentist checks that there is enough bone in the jaw to hold the implant. Things that can make implants less likely to succeed include smoking, uncontrolled diabetes, active gum disease and some medicines that affect bone. If there is not enough bone, a bone graft may be possible.

Dental implants: the stages of treatment

Dental implant treatment at Bright Smile Dental takes several visits over a number of months:

1. Consultation: the dentist examines your mouth, discusses your options and takes a 3D scan of your jaw to plan the exact position of the implant.
2. Implant placement: in a 90-minute surgical appointment, the implant is placed into the jawbone under local anaesthetic.
3. Healing: the bone bonds to the implant over roughly three to six months. A temporary tooth can often be worn during this time.
4. Fitting the crown: once the implant is secure, a custom-made crown is fitted on top.
5. Review: follow-up appointments check that the implant and gum are healthy.

Dental implants: looking after an implant

A dental implant needs the same care as a natural tooth: brushing twice a day, cleaning between the teeth, and regular check-ups. An implant cannot decay, but the gum and bone around it can become infected if it is not kept clean, which can cause the implant to fail.

Teeth whitening: what it is

Teeth whitening lightens the natural colour of your teeth. A whitening gel containing a bleaching agent is applied to the teeth to break down stains. Professional whitening at Bright Smile Dental can make teeth several shades lighter in one visit.

Whitening works on natural teeth only. It does not change the colour of crowns, veneers, bridges or tooth-coloured fillings. If you have fillings or crowns at the front of your mouth, they may need replacing after whitening so that they match.

Teeth whitening: who is suitable

Teeth whitening at Bright Smile Dental is offered only after a check-up to make sure your teeth and gums are healthy. Teeth whitening is not offered to patients under 18. The dentist will usually recommend waiting if you are pregnant or breastfeeding, or if you have untreated decay or gum disease, or very sensitive teeth.

Teeth whitening: what happens

A teeth whitening appointment at Bright Smile Dental lasts 60 minutes:

1. The shade of your teeth is recorded so the result can be compared afterwards.
2. A protective barrier is placed over your gums.
3. Whitening gel is applied to the teeth and left for a set time, then removed and reapplied.
4. The barrier is removed and the new shade is recorded.

Whitening does not need anaesthetic. Results vary between patients, and teeth with yellow stains usually respond better than teeth with grey stains. Whitening usually lasts between one and three years. It lasts longer if you avoid smoking and limit coffee, tea and red wine.

Teeth whitening: side effects

The most common side effect of teeth whitening is temporary sensitivity of the teeth, especially to cold. Some patients also notice mild irritation of the gums. Both usually settle within a few days. The Aftercare Instructions document explains how to manage sensitivity after whitening.